

Lab: Choosing Your Next Project

Objective

Practice planning a crochet project from start to finish, using Active Inference principles to evaluate project options, estimate materials, assess difficulty, and plan the execution.

Materials

- Access to crochet patterns (books, printed patterns, or online access)
- Your yarn stash or access to a yarn shop/website
- Pen and Planning Worksheet (template below)
- Ruler or tape measure
- Calculator (optional)
- Your crochet hook collection

Planning Worksheet Template

Project Options (list 3)

Option	Pattern Name	Difficulty (1-5)	Estimated Time	Yarn Needed	Yarn Available?	Excitement (1-5)	Confidence (1-5)
A							
B							
C							

Expected Free Energy Evaluation

Factor	Option A	Option B	Option C
Will I finish it?			
Will I learn something new?			
Do I have the materials?			
Will I be proud of the result?			
How much uncertainty is involved?			
Overall EFE ranking (1=best)			

Steps

Part 1: Generating Project Options (10 minutes)

1. Browse your pattern collection (books, saved patterns, online sources) and select **three potential projects** of different types and difficulty levels. They should be projects you would genuinely consider starting.
2. For each option, fill in the first row of the Planning Worksheet: pattern name, estimated difficulty (1-5), estimated time to complete, estimated yarn needed, whether you have the yarn available, your excitement level (1-5), and your confidence in completing it (1-5).

Part 2: Yarn Estimation Under Uncertainty (15 minutes)

1. For each project, estimate the total yardage of yarn needed. Use one or more of these methods:
2. Pattern's stated requirement
3. Your personal gauge calculation: (stitches per row) x (number of rows) x (average yarn per stitch)
4. Comparison to past projects of similar size

5. For each estimate, write a **confidence range**: "I am 80% sure I'll need between X and Y yards."
6. Check your stash. Do you have enough for each project? If not, what would you need to buy?
7. Note which project has the most uncertainty in yarn estimation and which has the least. Why?

Part 3: Difficulty Assessment — Self-Evaluation (10 minutes)

1. For each project, list the stitches and techniques required. Honestly assess: which do you know well, which have you done once or twice, and which are completely new?
2. Rate your readiness for each project (1-5). Compare this to the excitement rating from Part 1. Is there a tension between what you want to make and what you feel ready to make?
3. This is the **epistemic value** trade-off: a harder project offers more learning but more risk of frustration. A familiar project offers more confidence but less growth.

Part 4: Expected Free Energy Evaluation (10 minutes)

1. Fill in the Expected Free Energy Evaluation table. For each factor, rate each option (use words like "high," "medium," "low" or numbers 1-5).
2. Consider: which project will minimize your overall surprise and dissatisfaction while maximizing satisfaction and learning? This is the project with the lowest expected free energy.
3. Rank the three options. The highest-ranked option is your Active Inference-optimal project choice.

Part 5: Color Planning (Optional, 10 minutes)

1. If your chosen project involves color choices, lay out candidate yarn colors side by side.
2. Arrange them in the order they would appear in the project. Predict: will this combination look good in the finished fabric?
3. If possible, crochet a few stitches with each color in sequence to test your prediction. Compare the swatch to your mental image. How accurate was your visual simulation?

Part 6: Reflection and Discussion (10 minutes)

1. Share your planning worksheet with your crochet circle. Discuss:
 - Did everyone choose the same type of project, or did choices vary?
 - How did the expected free energy evaluation compare to your gut instinct?
 - What did you learn about your own planning process?

Discussion Questions

- Was the structured planning process (worksheet, ratings, evaluation) different from how you normally choose projects? Did it change your choice?
- Which factor had the most influence on your final decision: difficulty, yarn availability, excitement, or confidence?
- Did the difficulty assessment reveal any gaps in your skill set that you would like to fill?
- How might this planning framework help you avoid common crochet frustrations like running out of yarn, choosing projects that are too difficult, or abandoning projects midway?

Wrap-Up

You have practiced planning as an Active Inference agent: generating options, estimating under uncertainty, assessing your own capacity, and evaluating expected free energy. The project you selected is your generative model's best prediction for a satisfying next experience. Start crocheting — and bring your finished project to the circle when it is done.